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THE CONGRESS (LEFT) AND BJP (ABOVE) HAVE ACTIVATED THEIR WAR ROOMS

sists that it is not a "war room but a hub or meeting place. War room is a generic term imported from American media."

The first task of this think tank was to work out the slogan. It was Khurshid along with Anand Sharma who came up with the somewhat complicated 'Aam aadmi ke badte kadam, har kadam par Bharat bulund'. Setting the tone of the campaign, the core group decided against going 'too hi-tech'. Explains Khurshid, "It's the opposite of India Shining. This is an achievement-oriented campaign."

In keeping with the sober tenor, the Congress launched its revamped website without any 'bells and whistles' as Vishvijit Singh, the party's online choreographer, puts it with obvious reference to the L.K. Advani site.

Ramesh begins his day briefing ad agency professionals. The party has hired JWT, Crayons and Percept. The

first war room coup was that the Congress beat the BJP to the copyright of the popular song, *Jai Ho*. "The BJP may mock us now but they wanted this song. Only we beat them to it," chuckles a party strategist. Three 10-second films set to the *Jai Ho* score have already been released by Digvijay Singh who says that "the aim is to show what the Congress has done to empower the common man". To bring in the glamour quotient, film director Priyadarshan has been roped in to direct the ad films while fine arts photographer Rohit Chawla will be shooting the star campaigners, Rahul and Sonia.

Strategy aside, no campaign is complete without its tit-for-tat element. Known for his instant repartee, Ramesh is busy whipping up smashes to mock the BJP's travails. His latest offering is: *Varun-Arun ki kahani, khatam ho gaya Advani* (the Varun-Arun saga will finish off Advani's dreams). Sometimes it is also a guerrilla war room.

Charioteers on Fire

The target practice is over. The BJP is all set for the real thing. This time the party has gone hi-tech with a team of young management experts and techies forming the backbone of the attack. There is a video telephone on each desk, sophisticated laptops with high-end multimedia and video editing systems and a secure Wi-Fi working on a 4 Mbps bandwidth. While in one backroom of 26, Tughlak Crescent, the tech team is working on updating Advani's website and coordinating direct campaigns like *Advani@Campus*, in the other, the strategists are giving final touches to the details of the campaign.

Catchy slogans are being finalised. Strategies are being chalked out. Ideas fly thick and fast on what promises to make to the electorate and how to garner the most votes. They discuss the usefulness of using cinema theatres to advertise and a possible tie-up with Rajshri Productions.

The party has already chosen Frank Simoes and Tag for its TV and